convergence between Reagan and Zia than Rajiv and Reagan, despite the latter duo's excellent personal rapport. Moscow's growing frustration with the Afghan war and Gorbachev's willingness to negotiate with the US fell on deaf ears.

In November 1987, Soviet PM Nicolai Ryzhkov visited New Delhi to discuss Afghanistan among other issues such as Sri Lanka, where Rajiv had dispatched an Indian military contingent to disarm and demobilise various militant Tamil separatist groups and to facilitate provincial elections—only to get caught in a disastrous war with the LTTE. Ryzhkov made it clear to Rajiv that the US demand for a rushed Soviet withdrawal without guarantee of a representative coalition government was impossible. Rajiv agreed with Ryzhkov, and so did Afghan officials, who by now had begun worrying for their lives. In a response to 'Ronald' (and not Mr President) on 24 December 1987, Rajiv stuck to his position and informed the US president that Gorbachev and Najibullah were showing 'greater flexibility' than Reagan himself. In May–June 1988, Reagan and Gorbachev met at the Moscow Summit and signed the Intermediate Range Nuclear Force Treaty (INF) but made little progress on Afghanistan.[111] Rajiv's initiative with the two super powers had come to a naught.

Much to Reagan and Zia's consternation, India, by now, had activated a direct channel with former Afghan King Zahir Shah, who was still in Rome, to build a broad-based coalition government in case Najibullah did not last.[112] B Raman, an R&AW officer posted in Geneva from 1985 onwards—with Jaskaran Teja, India's former ambassador to Kabul and now the permanent representative in Geneva—had begun building links with Afghan exiles.[113] He facilitated high-profile meetings of these Afghans with Indian ministers, including then Minister of State for External Affairs Natwar Singh. Raman's groundwork paved the way for New Delhi to play the Zahir Shah card before the Geneva Accord that was signed between Afghanistan and Pakistan on 14 October 1988 with the Soviet Union and the US as guarantors. His links with India cost Zahir Shah dearly at Geneva, as he became a political untouchable in Islamabad.[114] A theoretical exercise at best, the accord failed to halt the Mujahideen offensives. Moreover, India's royalist gambit failed given Najibullah's disinclination to vacate the presidency. Adding insult to injury, India was not invited to attend the signing of the accord even as an observer, at Pakistan's insistence. As scholar Sergey Radchenko argues,